

The Silver Book of Cantations

—“Ah, Abrangih, right on time.”

As always, that little devil is waiting until the last moment to enter—as if he didn’t see her hovering in the hallway. The fact that she is avoiding him confirms his suspicions of her. But on to the story!

—“Come, sit here, Abrangih! I think it’s going to be about the Princess and the Knight.”

He waits for her to sit with the two sisters.

—“Alright, children, you convinced me that I should tell you this tale of perseverance in the face of adversity, of ingenuity against malevolence, of stalwartness before perfidy...”

Varaz always uses those big words which they don’t really get, but it makes it all the more exciting.

SO, it all started in the distant land of Hispania [Spain], where there lived an evil queen—I have even heard it been said that she was the incarnation of Shamiram herself. And we all know what a wicked queen she was, right? 🍷

Mom Shirin had once told them that Shamiram had actually been a noble Queen, but people misunderstood her. But they had decided amongst themselves that, at least for the purposes of the tales, she was bad.

—“Oh, yeah, she’s a witch!”

—“There is no such thing as a witch, Borān.”

Funny that he then would not question the magic of the Princess.

—“Well, I wouldn’t be so sure, Shirowe, because what I am about to tell you, I cannot explain differently than by witchcraft. But for a story to really ring true, we should hear it from the mouths of our protagonists, lest you would accuse me of falsifying the facts. For we all know that when the Princess or her Knight speak, they do not lie, for their thoughts are benevolent, their words are assuaging, and their deeds, well they are just plain heroic.”

SO, one day, the Princess gets a letter. And the Knight can see that the news in the letter greatly troubles her.

~“My Princess, what is it that you read that causes you this distress?”

~“It is a letter from noble Brunnahilt.”

~“Who is he, my Princess?”

~“It’s a she, my Knight. Brunnahilt is my grandaunt. She is the *Regia*,” children, you remember that is how the *Hromāyig* [Roman] call their queens, right, “*Regia* of the land of the Illustrious Quarrelers, a vast and wild land in the north. But grandaunt Brunnahilt is not from there. She was born in Hispania. And now, she wants her daughter to grow up in her home country. For there is a saying: of all the lands, which are from the west all the way to India, Hispania is the most beautiful, the sacred one, the happy one of princes, and the mother of peoples,¹ where the sun always shines and the sea is so blue.” You can’t believe it, children, how blue the sea is there. 🐉

—“Pff, there is no such land of the Illustrious Quarrelers.”

—“Oh, but there is, Shirowe, there is. Frankly, foremost famous for its fabled fighters.”

But, let’s listen what misfortune has befallen its *Regia*.

~“Grandaunt Brunnahilt has sent her lovely daughter, cousin Ingunda, to marry the Spanish prince Airmanagilt, a noble and valiant prince. But a vile witch lives in that country, my knight, an evil queen.”

~“An evil queen?”

~“A witch queen. With her magic, she has put a spell on the pious mother of Airmanagilt, so that she succumbed to a dreadful disease. And then—oh how evil she is—she kills her own husband, the *Rex*, and forces herself unto the father of Airmanagilt. She tells him to marry her, and if he does, he shall become *Rex* of all of Hispania, and his enemies will fall before him. Thus, beguiled by her seductive promises, he believes her. And he lets her put a spell on him, turning him into evil Ariusariman Rex. And through this vile plot, he attains leadership of Hispania and Gallia, resolving to expand the kingdom through war and increase its wealth.² But a mind poisoned by evil, turns darker every day. And so one day, he accuses his own son Airmanagilt of being perverted

¹Isidoros of Hispalis, Prologue.

²Isidoros of Hispalis, 602.

by his wife Ingunda, to commit blasphemous utterances and the performance of unholy sacraments. And so, he orders that he be executed."

~"Oh no, my princess, how can he turn against his own blood."

~"Such is the poison of that viper, my knight."

~"And what about princess Ingunda?"

~"She nearly escapes capture. And now, my grandaunt writes, she fears the same lot will befall her poor daughter. And she pleads with me to help find my cousin Ingunda, before Ariusariman Rex and his witch consort get to her."

~"Then we shall rescue her!" And so, the Princess and her Knight, they go in search of poor Ingunda. But someone else has heard about the plight of poor Ingunda, someone with far less noble intentions. Can you guess who? 🐉

By now, he has firmly established as arch-enemy daddy's former boss—the one he had been so terrified of that he would catch them on their flight to Persia—, and the children therefore also in unison shout out his name.

—"Gennadius!"

—"You guessed it."

Evil Gennadius thinks to himself

~"What if I am the one to capture fugitive Ingunda and then I will ask a high ransom for her return to Hispania. *Ewār* [surely], Ariusariman Rex will pay good coin for her. And if he doesn't, the Emperor will." So, you see, children, once more greed leads to the most evil deeds. And Gennadius sends all his minions to search for the innocent princess, and they find her in the imperial city of Malaka [Malaga], about to hide as a stowaway on a ship bound for Carthage. He sends word to Ariusariman Rex of her capture and that she is his for the price of tenthousand *drahm*. And when the letter reaches Ariusariman Rex and his evil witch Queen, with her venomous charms, she persuades her husband.

~"My liege, I made you Ariusariman Rex, ruler of the Goth and the Suebi, and so the price I ask from you in recompense is but a small one. Pay governor Gennadius the requested tenthousand coins. And then I will seize the girl by her hair

and throw her to the ground, and then I will kick her until she is covered with blood, and then I will have her stripped naked and order her to be thrown into the baptismal pool.³”

~“For you, I will do anything, my love. And after you have exacted your exorcism on her, I will find a fitting way to end the insolent girl’s miserable life.” And so they go to Malaka, pay evil Gennadius the tenthousand *drahm*, and they do unto the princess the most evil acts. Too gruesome to tell. And then Ariusariman Rex contrives a most wicked way for the poor princess to suffer.

~“With the magic that you imbued me, my consort in rule, I will petrify her into a statue. Or so it will seem for the unknowing eye. But she will still not be dead, but hear every curse, feel every sting, see every torment. So, Lord Gennadius, as your benefactor, I order you—for the necessary compensation, of course—to put her on a pedestal in the mighty city of Carthage, across from our sea, facing our lands, so that she can witness from across the sea, the punishment I will mete out to all the traitors of Hispania. And insolent Ingunda will witness everything yet will not be able to do anything about it. For the rule of Ariusariman Rex will be eternal and all who do not abide by my will, will be condemned to the fiery pits of hell!”

~“Of course, Your Grace, oh most benevolent One, Your wish is my command!” Gennadius’s mouth flatters, while his hand impatiently gestures to give him coin. ♣

He acts out the avaricious duplicity of the governor, making all the children laugh.

—“But the Princess and her Knight are going to come to princess Ingunda’s rescue, no?”

—“Alas, Āzar, I am afraid they might come too late.”

FOr they are completely unaware of what evil schemes are being plotted in the imperial city of Malaka. But Providence protects the meek! For when evil Ariusariman Rex is about to cast his curse unto the poor princess, a white falcon ascends on her shoulder. And quickly, she whispers in the

³Gregory of Tours, V.38.

bird's ears

~“Warn my cousin what is about to happen to me. By the soul of the *Senmurw*, hurry!” And as the bird flies away before the whip of the witch queen can hurt it, Ariusariman Rex utters this terrifying incantation unto the poor princess.
~“Petrificus Totalus!” And she turns into stone, trapped inside her own effigy. 🗿

—“Oh, how awful!”

—“Did the falcon warn the Princess and her Knight, Varaz. Will they come to her rescue?”

—“It did indeed, Abrangih.”

And when the Princess and the Knight hear the wicked plan of evil Gennadius, they hurry as quickly as possible to Carthage, before evil Gennadius can carry out his plan.

~“Look, my Princess, he is putting a statue up a pedestal.”

~“That is my cousin, my Knight! He will bolt her feet with big nails to the plinth. Oh dear, the pain would be excruciating! Hurry, we must save her. If we skulk quietly, we will take him by surprise.” But evil Gennadius, it is as if he has eyes on his back, for he suddenly turns around as his archenemies are advancing on him. And he realizes, he will not be able to foil their rescue. But his heart is dark and vengeful, and he thinks

~“If I cannot fasten princess Ingunda on this cliff overlooking the sea, then I will throw her in the waters of the sea, and from there, she can witness the destruction of everything that is dear to her, har, har.” And so, before our two heroes can get to Ingunda on time, he pushes her in the deep waters of the sea and then he runs away, his sinister laugh still sounding in their ears, as they look in horror down the cliff.

~“What shall we do, my princess. Should we dive behind her?”

~“Ariusariman Rex's incantation has turned her outer shell into granite, she will be too heavy, my knight, even for the two of us, and we will drown with her!”

~“But we cannot leave her there. She is your cousin!”
~“I know, my noble knight. We must seek help and I know just whom we should ask.” And she tells him her plan. ♪

This is the part of the story he loves most, as it involves one of his favorite mosaics from his former home in Kaisareia. Ironically, it was governor Gennadius who had shown it to daddy and him one day. And ever since, he would sneak once and a while into the garden where the pool with the mosaic of Odysseus and the Sirens was, to marvel at the scene, imaging himself to be Odysseus, but a stronger version, able to withstand the lure of the enchanting mermaids without having to cover his ears.

And it is a daring plan. Not one for the faint-hearted, children.
~“I will summon the enchantress Kirke.”
~“Who is she, my Princess?” ♪

—“Alright children, this is what I learned as a boy and I will not swear by its truth, for it sounds a little too fantastical. But according to the myths of the ancients, Kirke is the daughter of MEHR the Sun, and a Persian maiden.”

—“That is not possible!”

Wow, why does her friend get all so worked up. It’s all just stories. But mommy Mariam has warned her that with the Pahlav, by which she means her friends from house Mehrān and house Spahbedān, the issue of MEHR is a sensitive one. Apparently, that includes Abrangih’s family too. Yeah, who are her family actually? She’s going to ask later.

—“I agree, dear Abrangih, those might be just *Hromāyig* [Roman] tales of ignorance.”

But, children, whatever the divine lineage of Kirke, she is not to be trifled with. Many valiant knights have succumbed to her power. Hear!

~“My knight, she is the Queen of the Sirens, the mermaids who can salvage poor Ingunda from the waters.”

~“Very well, my Princess, then immediately summon Kirke and her Sirens.”

~“I am not sure, my Knight. It might not be safe. For you, for your honor. So, better perhaps I do this alone...”

~“*Pargast*, my Princess, if she and her maidens are so dan-

gerous, then I will definitely not leave your side. I will defend your honor with my life!"

~"Very well. But you cannot meet them like this, my dapper knight. There is one thing we will have to do with you."

~"Are you mocking my trousers. Or is it my boots. Shall I give them some extra waxing?"

~"Not your boots, my sweetness, but your ears."

~"Huh?"

~"For the Sirens' song can lure any man to the depths of the sea, and whomever is captivated by their enticing song cannot escape their clutches, for they are mischiefs who seek pleasure in bringing men to their detriment. And so we will have to plug your ears with wax. Unless, you want to be charmed by their song, being lulled to sleep, and torn by them to pieces.⁴"

~"A fate I would rather avoid, ha, ha. So waxing my ears then I will do." And so, the Princess summons Kirke. And when her Sirens notice that their mesmerizing song has no effect on the Knight, they turn to the task of salvaging poor Ingunda. And with their sweet voices, they entreat the waters to retreat so that they can haul the poor princess out of the sea. 🐚

—"Varaz, how come the Princess is not entranced by their song? Is it because she is a princess?"

—"Not her lineage but her gender, dear Borān, protects her. For as I said, the Sirens' spell only works on the male species. Don't ask me why, for I will just cover my ears with wax, ha, ha."

Hmm, a song like that could come in handy one day, especially with that bully brother Shirowe of her!

—"And so, they save princess Ingunda?"

—"Not quite yet, Āzar."

FOr the spell Ariusariman Rex put on her still makes her look and feel like a statue.

~"Great *nymfe* Kirke, many thanks for your help. But there is still this curse upon my poor cousin. Can your magic not free her?"

⁴Pliny, X.70.

~“Princess, I am afraid that is beyond even my capabilities. It is a very powerful and ancient spell, and only very few, if any, will still have knowledge of it.”

~“Oh, I know! Grandmama’s book!” And she sticks her finger in the air so enthusiastically, that it makes the Knight take the wax out of his ears to ask.

~“What did you say, my sweetness?”

~“Oh, no, my Knight, your ears. Hurry cover them. . .” 🐼

—“Oh no, children, will the song of the Sirens in the end lure him, will he be lost to the deep waters?”

Time for one of his pauses again, making them all shuffle anxiously on their cushion.

PHew! That was close, children, but the Sirens have already swam away, leaving the honor of our Knight intact. And before she dives after her *nymfes*, Kirke shouts.

~“I am not sure, Princess, that the book’s counterspells will be even potent enough.”

~“My Princess, what is she talking about.”

~“About grandmama’s book! It is the only thing that can help my poor cousin.”

~“Huh? A book?”

~“It is the *Silver Book of Cantations*, my knight. A magnificent book if there was ever any. It belongs to my grandmama. It contains all the wisdom of our ancestors, written down in silver letters on purple parchment. It’s our only hope.”

~“Where is it now?”

~“Hmm. My grandmama took it with her when she married a prince in a distant and cold land. But then there was a war, and she had to flee and leave the book behind. I don’t know what happened to it.”

~“We will find it, my Princess. But it is getting late and we should get some rest, so that tomorrow we embark on our quest for the *Silver Book of Cantations*.” The princess yawns.

~“You’re right, my Knight. Perhaps sleep will bring us counsel.” And indeed, for there is this marvelous magic, little known, of the white falcon, who comes visit you at night to give you advice. . . 🐼

—“Like my cousin,” they all look surprised at her friend Abrangih. What is she talking about, “well, . . . I mean, . . . he told me the story one day.”

She looks desperately at him for his aid.

—“The dream of the white falcon,” more proof that she knows his friend Xorra-Xosrow, for it was this secret that his friend had told him, that every night in his dreams a white falcon would come visit him. So, not only born in that land, not only a princess, but now even a cousin. And his friend Xorra-Xosrow has only one aunt. So, she must be her mother, making her part Deylam—explains her feisty nature, ha, ha. But who then was her father? Time though to deflect before the others start to grill the poor girl, “indeed, Abrangih, only very few know about its magic, and even less are blessed by its nightly visit.”

And thus, the white falcon comes to the Princess’s dream and tells her the whereabouts of the magical book. And the next morning, she tells the Knight

~“I know where the book is. My grandmama’s niece, princess Holycrux has it.”

~“She does? Where can we find her?”

~“When my grandmama had to flee from the war, she gave the book to her niece, sweet Holycrux, who took it with her to the land of the Illustrious Quarrelers, and she now keeps it in the monastery of the Queen’s Repentance,” he was pretty sure that there was such a monastery, called Metanoia, but he was equally sure that it was somewhere in the east, and not in Gallia [France]. He glances quickly at the *Bāmbishn*. And surely enough, he can tell from the little frown on her forehead, that she realizes its misplacement as well—how by all the saints does the *Bāmbishn* always know all these things—would she also have figured out the Queen Holycrux’s actual name, “Come, my knight, let us hurry to my grandmama’s niece.” And so, our intrepid duo, they quickly hurry to the monastery of the Queen’s Repentance, where princess Holycrux is its abbess, and they tell her about her kin, poor princess Ingunda. And she shows them the *Silver Book of Cantations*. The princess did not lie, it is the most magnificent book, bound in the finest leather, written in silver and golden ink. And so, they start searching for a coun-

terspell to Ariusariman Rex's curse, for an antidote to its potion.

~"Here," the princess points excited to a phrase written in golden letters, "a golden *Espiskevi* spell. They are the best. Do you think, princess Holycrux, that this can break Ariusariman Rex's evil curse?"

~"My dear kin, I am afraid that the *nymfe* Kirke may be right. It's mere incantation may not be sufficient to reverse this potent curse. But I have an idea. Though it will be difficult."

~"Tell us, dear princess Holycrux. Anything to save poor Ingunda."

~"If I were to have a piece of wood from the Cross on which they crucified our LORD, with its healing powers, not only could I imbue this curse with divine magic, but also, all the poor people of my land, I can heal them from the plagues that have beset us."

~"But are those holy relics not in the Holy City of Jerusalem? Will the Emperor grant us access?" ❧

—"Well, children, this is going to be another eventful adventure that I perhaps should tell you some other time."

—"No, tell, Varaz. We need to know if it will save poor Ingunda."

—"Okay, here is what we will do. Let us fast forward through the story:"

Off they go ... to Jerusalem, ... and the Patriarch ... and a little bird ... and yadda yadda yadda, behold, they return, triumphantly, with a piece of the True Cross, for that is what we *Tarsāg* [Christian] call it. And pious Holycrux—having now fulfilled the prophecy of her name—, she implores our LORD to manifest His powers in the incantation of the *Espiskevi* spell. And thus, the Princess and her Knight hurry back to Carthage, where poor Ingunda was still waiting for them at the same spot they had left her—yeah, statues don't wander around much, ha, ha. And with aid of the magic of the *Silver Book of Cantations* and the divine powers of the True Cross and the royal blood of its conjurer, in a commanding voice, the Princess weaves this incredible powerful *Espiskevi* spell:

*Give in himina jah ana airthai!*⁵

And behold, Ariusariman Rex's curse is undone, and Ingunda can move again. And crying, she falls in their arms ~"Oh cousin, if you wouldn't have come!" ~"It is your mother Brunnahilt who called me. So, hurry, she anxiously awaits you." So, children, what a tale, of divine defiance against wicked witchcraft! And it also inspired Airmanagilt's younger brother, who rises against his evil father and his demonic stepmother and frees the people of Hispania, while Ingunda is reunited with her mother again. A happy ending to a very disturbing story. ♣

Except that in reality, the ending was as disturbing as the rest, for poor Ingunda's bones were still resting in Carthage, never to be seen by her poor mother, while her little son was dragged all the way to Konstantinoupolis and the saints only know what had come of the poor boy. He sometimes identifies with the boy he has never met—and whose name he doesn't even know—, because his plight and that of his mother was not unlike his, except he was at least so lucky that his daddy survived his execution—and also, the story, it went in the opposite direction, ha, ha.

—"Did you like the story, Your Majesty," in anticipation of her questions, he stepped up to the *Bāmbishn* while she is trying to wake little Shasha, "I guess a little too long for the boy, ha, ha."

She turns to him, putting the boy back on the cushion.

—"Clever usage of the *dvandva* agglomerate behind which to hide the historical figure of *Rex Liubigild*," with the *Bāmbishn*, you always have to guess a little what she means, but presumably she has figured out that in Ariusariman Rex, he has combined the name of the heretic Areios with that of the deity AHRIMAN, their equivalent of Satan, "and likewise censoring his consort, queen Goiswintha's name. Nonetheless, fantastical elements, the occasional anachronism—the donation of a piece of the Holy Cross to the Queen is documented sixteen years prior to the execution of Airmanagilt—neologisms and literary liberties aside, entertaining as they may be, to which extent is the sojourn of Ingunda to Carthage historical?" —"For the children's sake, I omitted two details, Your Majesty. There was

⁵Silver Bible, M6:10.

no happy ending—the princess died in Carthage. I wanted to visit her tomb, but there was not enough time. And also, princess Ingunda did have a little boy whose name I cannot remember—if I do, I will let Your Majesty know—, who was taken hostage to Konstantinoupolis, but more do I not know about his fate either.”

—“Curious! Not returned to his maternal grandmother, Queen Brunnahilt. A pawn rather, in some unknown scheme of *Augustus* Maurikios. Another query: literary sources systematically Latinize names, yet you use what appears their vernacular form—Holycrux, Queen Radegunda’s alias obviously excluded,” yep, she has guessed the Queen’s name correctly—no surprise, “How was this linguistic proficiency acquired?”

—“I have learned these names from your cousin,” this cousin is more of a second or even a third generation one—he never could figure that one out—and everyone always calls her by her nickname, Peristerá [Dove], but that doesn’t sound appropriate, so he elaborates, “you know, Siavash’s mother.”

—“Of course, a fount of much knowledge. One that necessitates consultation then.”

The *Bāmbishn* always has this convoluted way of saying things: she just means that she is going to ask her cousin.

—“I am honored that my tales please you, Your Majesty.”

In the meantime, Shasha has awoken from his slumber, a little disappointed he has missed part of the story and whining that he is hungry. But before she leaves with the boy in her arms, she turns around one more time.

—“With the greatest admiration for manipulating the factual with the fictional. As Lady Kāren once said, a true gift is to:”

*Let fact with fiction be intertwined,
to yield a story more compelling
than either fact or fiction alone could bind.*